going up to a hundred on weekends. "Most tourists are from surrounding villages and a few from Mehsana and Ahmedabad," she says.

Vadnagar's glory long predates its most famous resident. It's believed that the town finds mention in the Puranas, as well as in Chinese Buddhist traveller Hiuen Tsang's 7th-century travelogues. Experts say a large part of the present-day town, which dates from the 18th-century Gaekwad period, is built over a mound of structures, possibly the remains from the various other dynastic periods it went through. Though the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) initiated serious study of the place only around 2006, a few years after Modi became the chief minister of Gujarat, various excavation projects have been undertaken since then. As of now, the town has 11 ASI-protected sites and monuments, and officials say that it has such a rich history that the entire area is now being treated as an ancient site. Its earliest settlements go back to circa 8th century BC, and its location—at an intersection of the highway linking Sindh to the late-ancient hubs of central India and the one from Gujarat's bustling ports to north India—was favourable. Over the years, researchers have found the remains of at least one Buddhist monastery, a Bodhisattva idol dateable to the second or third century, terracotta artefacts depicting scenes from the Jataka tales, and seals with Brahmi inscriptions. "We found a lot of interesting history related to Buddhism," says Y.S. Rawat, former director of the Gujarat state archaeology department. "Vadnagar was never a seat of power but a centre of soft power, culture and knowledge. [Artefacts associated with] Buddhist, Brahminical and Jain knowledge systems can be found here."

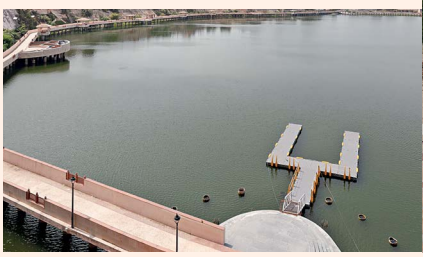
In 2022, the state government took over seven historical sites in the town (Kumar Shala No. 1 was one of them). The Union culture ministry has commissioned several research projects to study how the place has survived through centuries, its irrigation systems and network of water bodies, and infrastructure. Parts of a high fortification wall, which is believed to have been built by the Mauryas and within which the town grew, is currently the site of an elaborate study by the ASI. An experiential four-storey museum is coming up near it now. Vadnagar's famous Kirti Torans, a pair of 40-feet high columns of red and yellow sandstone thought to have been erected in the 12th century to celebrate victory in a battle, remain one of the key attractions.

Given such a treasured past, the government is focusing on not only the conservation of existing structures but also a civic revamp to enhance the town's tourism potential. "Vadnagar has survived through generations, it is immortal," says Gujarat tourism secretary Hareet Shukla. The iconic Nadiol Gate and Pithori Gate, believed to have been erected in the 11th and 12th centuries AD, have been restored, and the Chauta Adinath temple from that period and the 17th-century Hatkeshwar temple are being renovated as well. A music museum has been set up in memory of Tana and Riri, the twin sisters from Vadnagar who, per popular legend, once helped Emperor Akbar's court musician, Tansen, recover from illness by singing Raag Malhar for him. An old temple built in their honour has also been renovated, and open-air amphitheatres have come up in the past two years. Interestingly, a number of projects in Vadnagar have used the same pink traditional Sompura stones as seen at the under-construction Ram temple in Ayodhya.

Under a Rs 500-crore redevelopment project, Vadnagar's road network, underground drainage system and water supply are being enhanced too, in addition to the greening and landscaping of the town. The work is expected to be completed by 2027. The Sharmishtha lake is getting an elegant walkway around its periphery, and up to 10 lakes around the town are being interlinked to ensure round-the-year water supply for tourism activities. Equipment for boating and water sports activities already stands parked at a newly built jetty on the lake.

Connectivity is a priority too. "Vadnagar is part of a larger circuit we are developing in north Gujarat, centred around Dharoi, with Ambaji and Modhera," says Shukla. In 2021, the Vadnagar railway station complex got a swanky makeover, and the narrow gauge railway line was converted





In the Limelight

In December last year, Vadnagar was added to India's tentative list for UNESCO World Heritage Sites. Several steps have been taken in recent years to enhance tourism:

- **10 lakes around Vadnagar are being interlinked to ensure round-the-year water for tourism activities**
- **A four-storey museum will showcase the town's history and the various dynastic periods it witnessed**
- **The Hatkeshwar and Adinath temples have been refurbished**
- **A new art gallery has been set up,**